VIT VELLORE

# COMMUNICATION PORTFOLIO

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# *About This Portfolio*

COMMUNICATION IS NOT JUST ABOUT WORDS — IT IS ABOUT UNDERSTANDING. THIS PORTFOLIO EXPLORES COMMUNICATION AS A LIVED EXPERIENCE: HOW IT SHAPES RELATIONSHIPS, DRIVES CONFLICT, AND BUILDS BRIDGES ACROSS CULTURES. THROUGH THREE DISTINCT ENTRIES, I EXAMINE THE WAYS IN WHICH PEOPLE CONNECT, MISUNDERSTAND, AND ULTIMATELY FIND COMMON GROUND. EACH PIECE REFLECTS MY ENGAGEMENT WITH COMMUNICATION NOT AS A SUBJECT TO BE STUDIED, BUT AS A SKILL TO BE PRACTISED EVERY DAY.

# Case Study on Workplace Conflict Across Cultures :

WHEN A GLOBAL TECHNOLOGY COMPANY ASSIGNED A JOINT US-JAPAN TEAM TO DEVELOP A NEW CONSUMER PRODUCT, NO ONE ANTICIPATED THAT THEIR BIGGEST OBSTACLE WOULD NOT BE THE TECHNOLOGY — IT WOULD BE EACH OTHER.

ON THE SURFACE, THE COLLABORATION SEEMED STRAIGHTFORWARD. BOTH TEAMS WERE EXPERIENCED, TALENTED, AND MOTIVATED. WEEKLY VIDEO CALLS WERE SCHEDULED. SHARED DOCUMENTS WERE SET UP. TIMELINES WERE AGREED UPON. YET WITHIN THE FIRST MONTH, FRUSTRATION WAS QUIETLY BUILDING ON BOTH SIDES.

THE AMERICAN TEAM FELT INCREASINGLY CONFUSED BY THEIR JAPANESE COUNTERPARTS. IN MEETINGS, THE JAPANESE TEAM RARELY CHALLENGED IDEAS OUTRIGHT. WHEN ASKED FOR FEEDBACK, THEIR RESPONSES WERE POLITE BUT NON-COMMITTAL — "WE WILL CONSIDER IT," OR "THIS MAY NEED MORE THOUGHT."

TO THE AMERICAN TEAM, THIS READ AS DISENGAGEMENT OR PASSIVE RESISTANCE. ONE TEAM LEAD VOICED THE SHARED CONCERN BLUNTLY: "WE CAN NEVER TELL WHAT THEY ACTUALLY THINK. IT'S LIKE SHOUTING INTO A VOID." MEANWHILE, THE JAPANESE TEAM HAD THEIR OWN MOUNTING FRUSTRATIONS. THE AMERICANS PUSHED HARD IN MEETINGS — ASKING DIRECT QUESTIONS, PRESSING FOR IMMEDIATE ANSWERS, SOMETIMES CUTTING ACROSS OTHERS MID-SENTENCE. TO THEM, THIS FELT AGGRESSIVE AND DISRESPECTFUL, AS THOUGH THEIR PERSPECTIVE WAS NOT BEING GENUINELY HEARD. "THEY DON'T LISTEN," ONE MEMBER NOTED PRIVATELY. "THEY ONLY WANT TO BE AGREED WITH."

WHAT NEITHER TEAM INITIALLY RECOGNISED WAS THAT THEY WERE NOT DEALING WITH A PERSONALITY CONFLICT — THEY WERE DEALING WITH A COMMUNICATION CULTURE CONFLICT. THE AMERICAN TEAM OPERATED FROM AN INDIVIDUALIST, LOW-CONTEXT COMMUNICATION STYLE: DIRECTNESS WAS VALUED, DISAGREEMENT WAS NORMAL, AND SPEAKING ONE'S MIND WAS A SIGN OF ENGAGEMENT. THE JAPANESE TEAM, BY CONTRAST, CAME FROM A COLLECTIVIST, HIGH-CONTEXT CULTURE WHERE HARMONY WAS PRIORITISED, DISAGREEMENT WAS EXPRESSED INDIRECTLY, AND PUBLIC CONFRONTATION WAS CONSIDERED DISRESPECTFUL.

THE TURNING POINT CAME WHEN A SENIOR PROJECT MANAGER ARRANGED A STRUCTURED INTERCULTURAL WORKSHOP FOR BOTH TEAMS. RATHER THAN ADDRESSING INDIVIDUAL COMPLAINTS, THE SESSION FOCUSED ON EDUCATING BOTH SIDES ABOUT THE OTHER'S COMMUNICATION NORMS. THE AMERICAN TEAM LEARNED TO READ BETWEEN THE LINES — TO TREAT HESITATION AND CAREFUL PHRASING AS MEANINGFUL FEEDBACK, NOT SILENCE. THE JAPANESE TEAM, IN TURN, BECAME MORE COMFORTABLE FLAGGING CONCERNS DIRECTLY IN WRITING, WHICH FELT LESS CONFRONTATIONAL THAN VERBAL PUSHBACK.

OVER THE FOLLOWING WEEKS, THE TEAM INTRODUCED A NEW PRACTICE: WRITTEN PRE-MEETING NOTES WHERE EVERYONE COULD SHARE THOUGHTS BEFORE THE CALL, GIVING THE JAPANESE TEAM SPACE TO COMMUNICATE ON THEIR OWN TERMS. MEETINGS BECAME MORE BALANCED. DECISIONS BECAME MORE COLLABORATIVE. THE CONFLICT DID NOT DISAPPEAR OVERNIGHT — BUT IT TRANSFORMED FROM A SOURCE OF DIVISION INTO A GENUINE UNDERSTANDING OF HOW DIFFERENTLY PEOPLE CAN COMMUNICATE, AND STILL ULTIMATELY MEAN THE SAME THING.

# Reflection :

THIS ENTRY DOCUMENTS A REAL-WORLD WORKPLACE CONFLICT ROOTED IN CROSS-CULTURAL MISCOMMUNICATION BETWEEN AN AMERICAN AND JAPANESE PRODUCT TEAM. THE PURPOSE OF THIS PIECE IS TO EXAMINE HOW COMMUNICATION STYLES — SHAPED BY CULTURAL VALUES — CAN LEAD TO SERIOUS PROFESSIONAL FRICTION EVEN WHEN BOTH PARTIES ARE ACTING IN GOOD FAITH.

THE TARGET AUDIENCE IS ANYONE NAVIGATING MULTICULTURAL OR PROFESSIONAL ENVIRONMENTS — STUDENTS ENTERING GLOBAL WORKPLACES, HR PROFESSIONALS, OR TEAM LEADS MANAGING DIVERSE GROUPS. THE NARRATIVE IS WRITTEN TO BE ACCESSIBLE TO GENERAL READERS WHILE REMAINING GROUNDED IN REAL ORGANISATIONAL DYNAMICS.

THIS ENTRY CONNECTS DIRECTLY TO THE PORTFOLIO THEME OF COMMUNICATION BY HIGHLIGHTING HOW THE SAME WORDS — OR THE ABSENCE OF THEM — CAN CARRY ENTIRELY DIFFERENT MEANINGS DEPENDING ON CULTURAL CONTEXT. IT DEMONSTRATES THAT EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION IS NOT JUST ABOUT LANGUAGE, BUT ABOUT UNDERSTANDING THE VALUES AND NORMS THAT SHAPE HOW PEOPLE CHOOSE TO EXPRESS THEMSELVES. THE RESOLUTION OF THE CONFLICT, ACHIEVED THROUGH EMPATHY AND STRUCTURAL CHANGE, REFLECTS COMMUNICATION AS BOTH A SKILL AND A RESPONSIBILITY.

# AI Usage Disclosure

IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE PORTFOLIO SUBMISSION GUIDELINES, I HEREBY DISCLOSE THE FOLLOWING REGARDING MY USE OF AI TOOLS IN THE PREPARATION OF THIS PORTFOLIO.

COMPONENT AI TOOL NATURE OF USE
CLAUDE (ANTHROPIC) FOR STRUCTURING AND DRAFTING.

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